3.1 The Abolition Movement

Reformers in the 19th century didn't have cell phones or social media to spread the word. Instead, they wrote letters and newspaper articles, gave speeches, and even sent secret messages to communicate their ideas.

MAIN IDEA Brave individuals spoke out about the injustices of slavery in an attempt to end the institution in the United States.

SPEAKING OUT AGAINST SLAVERY

Many reformers who spoke out about social issues were also **abolitionists**, or people who wanted to end slavery. However, some Americans did not agree with abolitionists. Southerners and northerners alike considered abolitionists and their ideas too radical—as well as dangerous, un-Christian, and even unpatriotic.

In 1831, an abolitionist named **William Lloyd Garrison** published the first issue of his newspaper, *The Liberator.* His paper called for the immediate **emancipation**, or freedom, for all enslaved people. **Wendell Phillips**, a wealthy attorney, soon allied with Garrison. He wrote for *The Liberator* and contributed financially to the movement.

In 1839, former President John Quincy Adams argued that the ideals of the Declaration of Independence applied to all people. He called for a constitutional amendment to make every child born in the United States after July 4, 1842, free. He also proposed that no new state could enter the Union if it allowed slavery, but neither idea became law.

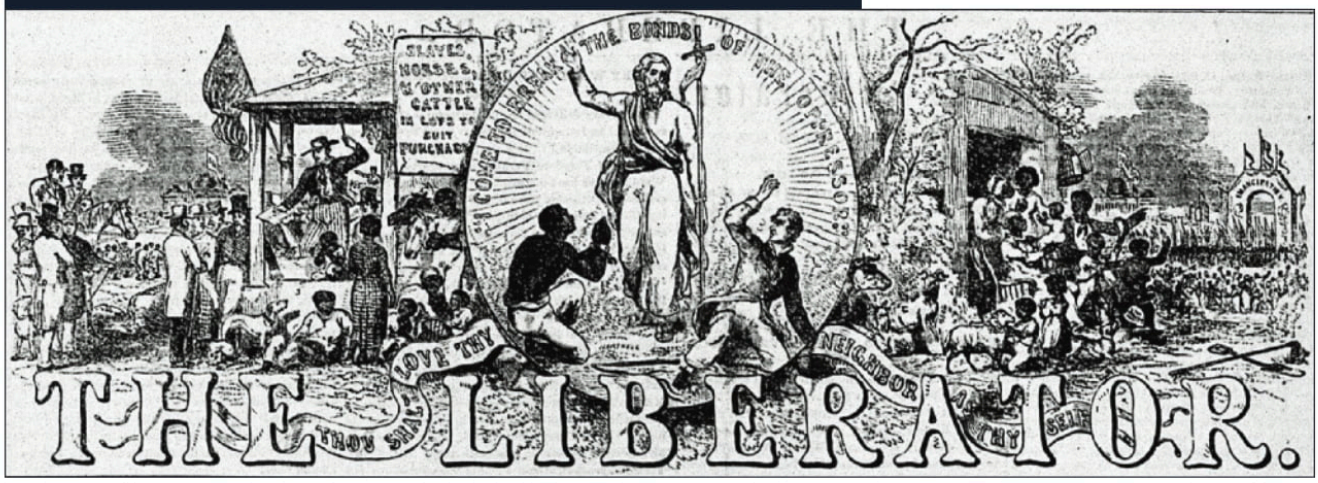
Two sisters, **Sarah Grimké** and **Angelina Grimké**, witnessed the cruelty of slavery firsthand while growing up on their parents' plantation in South Carolina. When the sisters took up the abolitionist cause, as some southerners did, their family disowned them. These determined women joined the Quakers and traveled the country giving speeches in support of abolition. In 1863, Angelina



The Iron Collar
One of the most horrifying tools slave owners subjected enslaved people to was the iron collar. They used this device to punish slaves, especially for attempts to escape. The prongs made it impossible to lie down to rest or sleep. They also caught on bushes and underbrush, making it hard to run. Abolitionists pointed to this kind of cruelty in demanding an end to slavery.

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William Lloyd Garrison published the weekly newspaper *The Liberator* for 35 years, beginning in 1831. The masthead, or title area, depicts enslaved people before and after liberation.



Grimké married fellow abolitionist **Theodore Weld**, a trainer and recruiter for the American Anti-Slavery Society.

STANDING UP FOR FREEDOM

Both free and enslaved African Americans actively challenged the existence of slavery. **David Walker** was a free African-American man who wrote for *Freedom's Journal*, an abolitionist newspaper. As the owner of a secondhand clothing store in Boston in the 1820s, Walker printed antislavery pamphlets and sewed them into the pockets of clothing he sold to sailors. Walker hoped the pamphlets would reach people in many ports, especially those in the South. One of his pamphlets, entitled *An Appeal to the Coloured Citizens of the World,* became one of the most radical antislavery documents of the movement, and southern states reacted by prohibiting the circulation of abolitionist literature.

Another African-American abolitionist was **Charles Remond**, who was born to a wealthy, free African-American family in Salem, Massachusetts. He worked as an agent of the Massachusetts Anti-Slavery Society, and he traveled and spoke with Garrison, Phillips, and others.

Robert Purvis was the son of a wealthy cotton broker and a free African-American woman. When he was nine years old, his family moved from South Carolina to Philadelphia. As an adult, Purvis became very active in abolition and in the **Underground Railroad**. In fact, he and his wife, **Harriet Forten**, housed escapees in their home, also known as the Purvis "safe house."

At the beginning of the chapter, you read about the courageous work of **Harriet Tubman**. Other African-American women played significant roles in the abolitionist movement as well. **Harriet Jacobs**, born into slavery, escaped to New York in 1842. She published *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl* in 1861, considered one of the most extensive slave narratives written by a woman.

Sojourner Truth was also a powerful abolitionist voice. Like Tubman and Jacobs, Truth was born into slavery. When she told a white neighbor that her owner broke his promise to release her, the neighbor paid the owner $20 for her and then set her free. She changed her enslaved name, Isabella, to Sojourner Truth. She captivated people with her simple, clear message: that all people deserved the same rights as white men.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did abolitionists work to end slavery?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why did most Americans consider abolitionists' ideas radical?
3. **ANALYZE VISUALS** What details do you notice in the photo, and how might those—and the photo itself—have impacted people who saw it in the mid-1800s?

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